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Not free, not fair, not credible

Did Britain Back a Zimbabwean Autocrat's Re-election?

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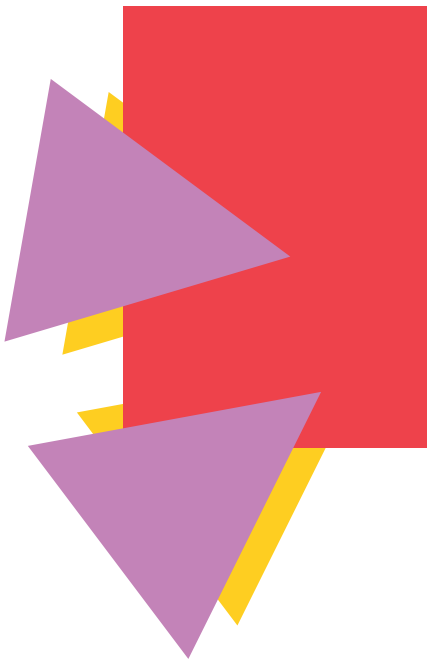
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"WHAT ARE THOSE?"

A Meditation on Moobs

BY **T.C. MARTIN**

WHEN I GOOGLE "MOOBS," the search results can be divided into three categories. One category gives definitions of the word. *Dictionary.com* takes a scientific route, describing moobs as "overdeveloped breasts on a man, caused by excess weight or lack of exercise." *Urban Dictionary* puts it more bluntly: moobs are "what happens when fat gathers in a male's chest area, and gives him the appearance of having breasts." A portmanteau of the words "man" and "boobs," the word "moobs" is demonstrated in a brief dialogue on *Urban Dictionary* that goes as follows:

> Person A: *"Those moobs are quite sizeable."*
> Person B: *"Indeed."*

The second category contains articles about the addition of the word to the *Oxford English Dictionary* in September 2016. The *OED* adopted the word "moobs" along with "YOLO" and "Oompa Loompas," the hyper-tanned Dahlian characters whose bodies we love to mock.

But by far the most common of the search results are advice columns, men's articles, and how-to pages on curing yourself of your moobs. Though moobs can be acquired in several ways (including a hormonally-spurred enlargement of breast tissue, known as gynecomastia, common in teenage boys), these articles mainly focus on the moobs of fat men. According to National Institutes of Health (NIH) statistics, approximately 74 percent of American men are "overweight" or "obese." (I place these terms in quotes due to the NIH's use of Body Mass Index, or BMI, to define them. There is a growing body of evidence showing that BMI is a deeply flawed measurement of human health.) After doing some quick math on the back of a Wendy's to-go bag, I figure there are roughly 240 million moobs in the U.S. that supposedly need eradicating.

You would think from reading some of these search results that moobs are an otherworldly plague on mankind. A piece from *Askmen*, a free online web portal with the slogan, "Become a Better Man," pronounces that moobs are "every man's worst nightmare," and a *Men's Health* article advises readers to "banish" their moobs. Most columns offer the standard solution of diet plus exercise (although usually dressed up with phrases such as "eat like a man" and "become one with the bench [press]," according to *GQ*). A *WikiHow* page offers multiple paths to mooblessness, including: wearing looser shirts; wearing collared shirts; wearing shirts with built-in girdles (which I, a moob-owner, did not even know existed); wearing shirts on top of shirts; committing to losing weight; making an exercise plan; sticking to your exercise plan; and saving enough money—a mere 5,000 dollars—to undergo elective cosmetic surgery. The last of these options is accompanied by an image: a drawing of a middle-aged man post-moobectomy, fist-pumping the air without a hint of jiggle.

I'VE HAD MOOBS for as long as I can remember because I've been fat for as long as I can remember. It's no secret why: during my elementary school years, a home-cooked meal was harder to come by than a ten-piece chicken McNugget with fries. My physical activity consisted exclusively of napping outside on a sagging trampoline and spotty attendance at a weekly boys' tumbling class held at my local gym.

A dozen or so boys, myself included, would (sometimes) show up to this class and cartwheel, backbend, and flip (sort of) across the spongy gym floor, all while our mothers peered down from a raised observation deck and pretended not to see us prancing between exercises. While waiting for my turn on the trampoline, I would always watch the girl gymnasts perform their acts. Not because I was interested in them—I was much too young and much too gay for that—but because I envied their leotards.

Boy gymnasts had to wear athletic shorts and shirts, with or without sleeves. The girl gymnasts' leotards, colorful and sleek and shimmering, made me long jealously for a type of a beauty that seemed categorically inaccessible to me.

I was waiting patiently in the trampoline line when the short, thin boy in front of me turned around and, with absolutely no pretense, extended a bony finger and probed my left moob.

"What are those?" he asked in an annoyingly high-pitched voice. Apparently, he had never seen anything resembling a breast before.

"That's my chest," I responded, retreating from his grope.

"They look like my mom's," he said, twisting the word "mom" into something cruel and demeaning. "Why are they so...big?" he pressed. He looked at me with the same disgusted curiosity he might show a rotting millipede. Before I could respond, he hopped onto the trampoline and executed an infuriatingly flawless routine.

Beyond that single conversation, this boy does not exist in my memory. I do, however, remember our class instructor telling us that in order to gather the most spin on our jumps, we should tuck our arms by crossing them over our bodies. I remember stepping onto the trampoline and folding my arms across my abundant chest. I flattened my moobs against my rib cage and felt them pressing against my very core.

PERHAPS THE PLACE most accepting of moob-owners is the beach. When I was younger, my family drove eight hours every summer to visit Myrtle Beach in South Carolina, and we could hardly throw a Frisbee around there without it rebounding off the portly chest of some male sunbather. The beach was popular among residents of the numerous senior living communities in Horry County, so it probably had a higher moob concentration than most places. Through sheer habituation, beachgoers at Myrtle became desensitized to the moob's peaceful, flabby presence. In fact, moobs are so prevalent there that in low-resolution photographs with poor lighting, Myrtle could be mistaken for a clothing-optional beach.

You would think from reading some of these search results that moobs are an otherworldly plague on mankind.

One summer I ditched the annual Myrtle trip to travel to Barcelona with my Spanish class. Our teacher, Mrs. Posey, allotted us one beach day only, and during the metro ride to the shoreline she briefed us on a crucial detail: the beach was clothing-optional. We were enthralled.

We weren't actually considering getting undressed (except for a strap-

ping football player with moob-scale pecs who flirted with the idea). We were mostly intrigued by a visit to a place where the human body could openly exist in its purest state: without clothes.

We burst out of the suffocating Barcelona metro and spilled onto the beach. Keeping my eyes focused on the ground directly in front of me, I shuffled along with the group to a small parcel of sand. I laid down my towel, shucked off my T-shirt, and rushed to the safe cover of the warm Mediterranean water.

My classmates followed suit. Soon we were all paddling around, splashing each other and disrupting the quietude of the beach. The distance made looking directly at the nude beachgoers easier, but also more taboo—almost voyeuristic. It was surprisingly hard to spot the naked ones from our vantage point. The shoreline blended into a corpulent collage of thighs, bellies, and—yes—moobs.

My moobs have thrown into sharp relief the demands of masculinity and femininity. They are my body's rebellion against manhood—or at least, how manhood is meant to behave.

As the minutes passed, we got more adept at noticing the subtle curve of an uncovered breast, the sagging asymptote of a bare butt cheek. We were like tourists on a safari silently pointing out exquisite specimens to one another. *Those moobs are quite sizeable*, our knowing glances said. *Quite sizeable indeed.* We filed each sighting in our mental folder labeled "Weird Things Europeans Do," along with charging for soft drink refills and showing uncensored nudity in mid-afternoon television commercials. After we had dried off and I had donned my shirt again, we sprawled out on our towels and continued our people-watching.

To my right, a stocky, middle-aged man crouched over his crying two-year-old daughter, desperately trying to shush her with a pacifier. His matronly moobs swayed as he lovingly shoved the plastic bit into the kid's mouth. The girl gradually calmed and began smiling and giggling at her busty father. Soon the two of them were waddling toward the water, splashing their feet in the shallow edges of the water, jiggling together.

To my left, an older gentleman reclined on his beach towel, one arm extended fully above his head, the other elbow-deep into a bag of Ruffles. His moobs drooped proudly off to either side of his body. He slowly extracted a single potato chip and, with a grand flourish, lowered it vertically into his mouth. There was something formally graceful in his movements. Paint in a couple rosy-cheeked cherubs and some august marble columns, and replace the chips with a cluster of purple grapes, and the man would have looked positively classical.

It wasn't the dazzling spectacle of a leotard, but it was something.

MAYBE IT'S NOT the appearance of moobs that invites so much scorn, but rather what they represent. At their most basic level, breasts imply femininity. That simple association belies the complex relationships women and men, especially those who participate in artistic sports, can have with their bodies.

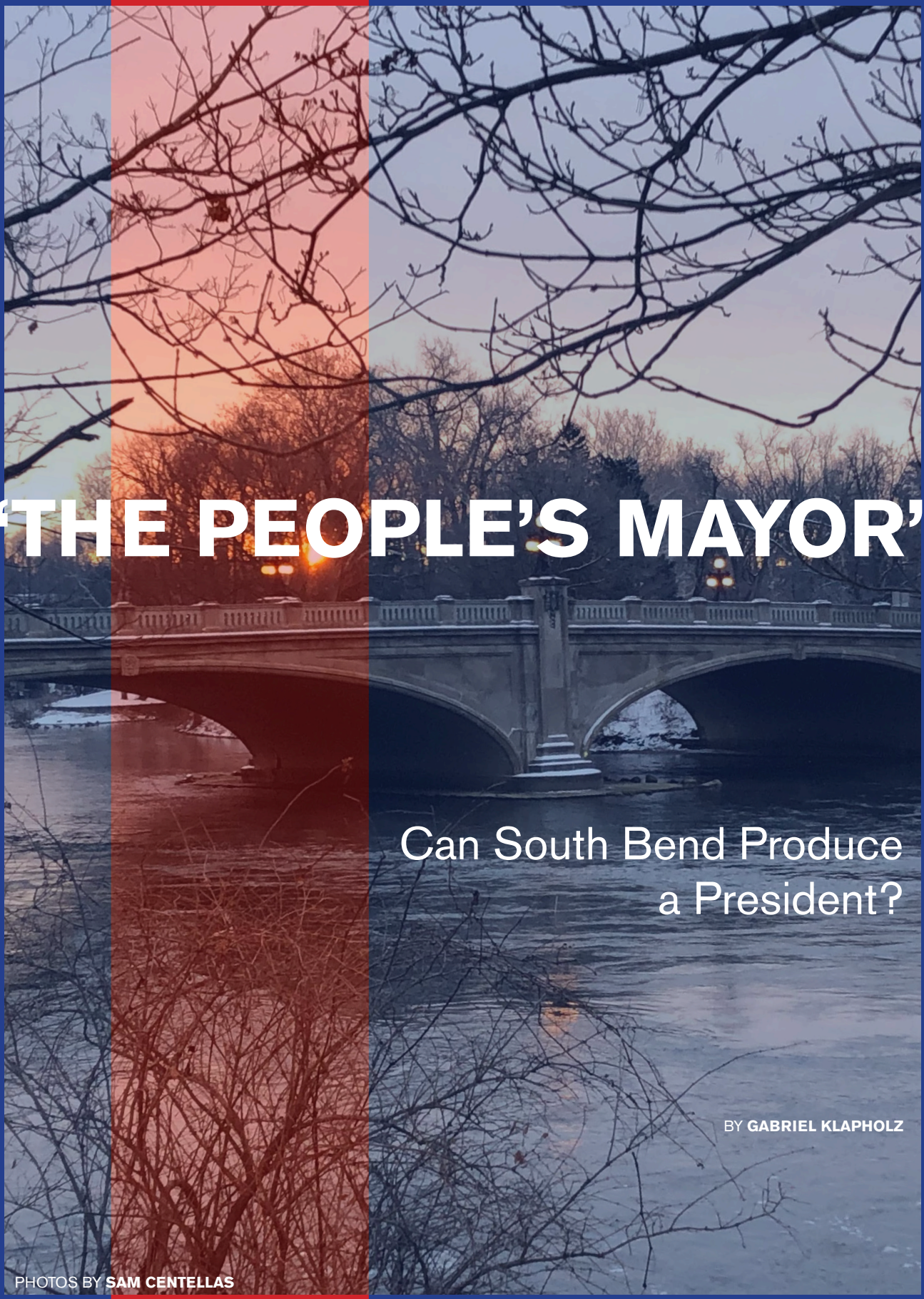
As a young male gymnast, I wasn't aware of the intense bodily scrutiny directed at the female athletes I so admired. In a brilliant essay published in the *Yale Daily News* in 2017, Liana Van Nostrand '20 wrote about her experience as a dancer and her decision to undergo breast reduction surgery. My admiration, brought from a place of deep insecurity and internalized stigma against fatness, flattened the experiences of my fellow athletes. Breasts are more complicated than I had thought—for people of all genders.

For me, my moobs have thrown into sharp relief the demands of masculinity and femininity. They are my body's rebellion against manhood—or at least, how men are meant to behave. Men are not supposed to prance around in bedazzled, skintight leotards; men should not lounge serenely on the coast, engorging themselves on junk food; and men, above all else, should not be motherly.

And I think that's bullshit.

The summer after I went to Barcelona, I visited Virginia Beach with a few of my high school friends. We had all just graduated and were about to scatter ourselves between four distant universities. My friends weren't much for swimming, and there's really nothing lonelier than floating shirtless through the trashy brine of the Virginian coast, so we spent most of our time sunbathing. I set up our umbrella with every intention of reclining beneath its protective shade, safely covered by my dark-blue T-shirt.

Then I remembered that annoying boy from tumbling class. And the unapologetic nudists in Barcelona. *Fuck it*, I thought, and flung off my shirt. With the salty breeze wicking at my ample moobs, I felt utterly free.



“THE PEOPLE’S MAYOR”

Can South Bend Produce a President?

BY **GABRIEL KLAPHOLZ**

PHOTOS BY **SAM CENTELLAS**

AS STUDENTS RETURN to school and autumn sets in, South Bend, Indiana, gears up for football season. It is easy to tell when game day has arrived in this town of just over 100,000 people, home to the University of Notre Dame and their Fighting Irish. Bottlenecks block up traffic in the northeastern portion of the city, where the university is located. The cars are filled with cheap beer, South Bend locals, Notre Dame students, and die-hard fans from across the country.

"It's really hard to find a parking space. Some people will rent out their own driveways as a way to offer more parking," said 19-year-old Emma Lyandres, who grew up in South Bend and whose father teaches Russian history at Notre Dame.

Former mayor of South Bend Stephen Luecke knows the drill on game day: "The best time to do your grocery shopping is before or during a football game, because nobody else is around."

In many ways, South Bend is like any other college town. But there is far more to the city than tailgates and the Fighting Irish. After the loss of manufacturing jobs in the early 1960s, South Bend experienced an economic decline characteristic of cities across the Rust Belt. Now, the city is finally reinventing itself, decades after the automotive industry abandoned it to ruin.

In October 2018, after nearly six years in office, Pete Buttigieg, the current mayor of South Bend, said that he would not be seeking re-election. Instead, in January 2019, he announced that he would be running for president. Buttigieg claims that South Bend's revival under his leadership is evidence that he can bring about change on the national scale.

Buttigieg, a Harvard graduate, Rhodes scholar, and Afghanistan War veteran, is a Democrat and the first openly gay municipal executive in Indiana. His presidential campaign has inspired a media firestorm, offering South Bend and its story a national audience. Still, the path to the presidency has many hurdles, and doubts remain about how much change Buttigieg can take credit for.

AT THE HEART of Indiana's predominantly white St. Joseph County, South Bend is a blend of university students and professors; families who, a few generations ago, worked in the now-shuttered Studebaker factory; young professionals; and large black and Hispanic communities.

Because of its size, South Bend's community enjoys an intimacy unusual in larger cities. It would not be abnormal to run into "Mayor Pete," explained Lyandres, whose parents know Buttigieg's parents personally.

"I think one of the things that was really special about growing up in South Bend was knowing everyone in my neighborhood," she said. "Living in a place where there's not many things to do all the time, it forces you to make friends with people. You go over to people's houses and sit there and talk and hear their stories. This made my connections with people much more personal."

Downtown South Bend has no chain restaurants."Everything is kind of kitschy and local," Sam Centellas, the executive director of the Latino community center La Casa de Amistad, said. And because of the university, he noted, the city is much livelier than other Midwestern cities of its size.

On weekends, South Bend boasts a farmers' market along the St. Joseph River. Local small business owners come to sell everything from popcorn and fresh vegetables to artwork. "There's everything you can imagine and more," said Courtney Becker, the editor-in-chief of the Notre Dame newspaper *The Observer*. "When I stay here for Thanksgiving, that's where I go to get my ingredients."

The city has its own nightlife—bars frequented by locals and college students alike—as well as art galleries and a local theater.

Despite South Bend's flourishing farmers' market and growing downtown area, remnants of the city's abandoned industries still loom large. For decades, the Studebaker automotive manufacturing plant stood at the center of the city's existence. Signs of that legacy endure, from the palatial Tippecanoe Place that was once a home to the company's founder, Clement Studebaker, to the many local businesses and firms that emerged as a result of the industry. NCP Coatings used to provide custom paint jobs for Studebaker vehicles, and is still in the paints business today. For years, old and vacated buildings that once housed the massive Studebaker operation lined city streets. Only in the last decade has the city started tearing down or repurposing them.

When the Studebaker factory closed in December 1963, the city underwent an "identity crisis," South Bend City Council President Tim Scott said. Ever since then, the city has been trying to recuperate the 7,000 jobs it lost, which constituted eight percent of the county's total employment.

The 2008 recession did not help. South Bend experienced some of its gravest economic woes in its wake. Immediately in the wake of the economic downturn, the state of Indiana imposed heavy property tax caps to force municipalities to spend more effectively by limiting their funds. The government of South Bend needed to cut its budget of 120 million dollars by one-sixth.

"There weren't companies looking to expand and invest in that time," said Luecke, who served as the city's mayor from 1997 to 2011. Eventually, the city had to institute a local income tax to make ends meet.

In 2011, many of the Studebaker manufacturing plants had yet to be torn down. That same year, *Newsweek* placed South Bend on its list of "America's Dying Cities." Soon, however, things began to turn around—which many residents attributed to Buttigieg's policies and efforts aimed at generating excitement among businesses and investors.

"Buttigieg has been going out

"PETE IS REALLY BRINGING THAT RUST BELT FLY-OVER AREA OF AMERICA TO THE TABLE. WE'RE KIND OF FORGOTTEN ABOUT."

trying to recruit youthful energy to promote and capture businesses here in South Bend," Scott said.

With an influx of young people interested in starting businesses, Scott explained, as well as Notre Dame and Indiana University South Bend forming local partnerships and incubators, the city has been able to attract new startups and reshape its economy.

One of Mayor Buttigieg's largest initiatives is called Smart Streets, which he first introduced at a budget hearing in 2013. The ongoing project is aimed at reinvigorating the city through developing two-way traffic flow and enhancing overall street quality, with new curbs, sidewalks, and street lights.

Positioned on key railroads and highways, South Bend attracts entrepreneurs. Heavy investment in technology in the last decade has helped fuel the city's economic comeback. "We are now one of the largest centers for data technology in Indiana," Scott said.

"There has certainly been large development in downtown South Bend, as well as greater partnerships with Notre Dame," said Alan Achkar, executive editor of the *South Bend Tribune*, the city's largest newspaper. "We have seen several older dilapidated buildings in the downtown area being transformed into lofts and housing."

Now, the former Studebaker manufacturing facility, Building No. 84, which offers 800,000 square feet of open space, is being converted into a technology hub. The old rail depot, which fell to disuse in the early 1970s, now houses tech companies as the Union Station Technology Center.

"Notre Dame just partnered with General Electric to do research on jet engines," Scott said, "all on old Studebaker grounds."

"THE PEOPLE'S MAYOR" is what Centellas called Buttigieg in an interview with *The Politic*. "Mayor Pete" speaks fluent Spanish, and he will often come into Centellas' largely Latino neighborhood to have lunch with locals.

In a quarterly meeting a few years ago with Latino leaders in the city, members of a local Mexican church came to discuss ways that parishioners could gain easier access to photo identification. In the middle of the meeting, after sharing a few updates, Centellas remembered that Buttigieg stopped and said, "Should we do this in Spanish?"

"He goes into his speech talking about issues like combined sewer overflow, all in Spanish," Centellas recalled.

It is no coincidence that South Benders speak highly of Buttigieg: the mayor was last elected in 2015 with over 80 percent of the city's vote. Now, he seeks to turn his local persona into a national one. Citing South Bend's recent economic success, Buttigieg buoyantly claims to represent a new future for Americans. The mayor has branded himself as a voice of reason in an otherwise toxic political atmosphere.

In an interview with *New York Magazine*, Buttigieg said that the country needs a "reckoning with nostalgia" to honor the past "but not get sucked into it, not get resentful about it, either." South Bend, he explains, has been through that reckoning already, under his leadership. Like South Bend, Buttigieg says, the nation needs to let go of the past and embrace economic and political change.

In the wake of President Trump's electoral success in the Midwest, Buttigieg believes he can sway voters. "Pete is really bringing that Rust Belt fly-over area of America to the table. We're kind of forgotten about," Scott said.

Trump's 2016 run also undermined the traditional path to the presidency, noted Achkar, the editor of the *South Bend Tribune*, paving the way for outsiders like Buttigieg. No longer does one have to be a senator or governor before throwing their hat in the ring, he said.

Still, Buttigieg's prospects of victory are slim, at best. "There are a million hurdles facing him in this race," Achkar said. Up against heavy-hitters like Elizabeth Warren, Kamala Harris, and Cory Booker, Buttigieg has to worry about name recognition, fundraising, and the daunting possibility that his message simply won't resonate with voters.

Questions remain about the degree to which Buttigieg can boast of his success in South Bend. The city still grapples with deep ongoing problems. According to a September 2017 study conducted by Prosperity Now, economic insecurity in South Bend is especially pronounced in communities of color. Hispanic households in the city have an income poverty rate of 32.9 percent, ten points higher than the national Hispanic income poverty rate. The median household income of African Americans in South Bend, who make up about a quarter of the



city's population, is 14,000 dollars lower than the national average; 40.2 percent of African Americans in South Bend fall below the poverty line, which is nearly double the national poverty rate for African American households.

As Centellas puts it: South Bend is a "screaming example" of white flight.

Recent population trends in the city show that since the 1990s, white residents have been leaving as the city's black and Hispanic populations have been growing. The problem has continued during Buttigieg's tenure: the white population of the city fell from around 63,000 in 2010 to about 54,486 in 2017.

"We now have little suburb cities like Granger, Mishawaka, and Osceola that are extremely high percentage white, and that are much better off socio-economically," Centellas said.

Nevertheless, Centellas remains hopeful. The city is currently conducting research to gain a better understanding of its problems and possible solutions. "We're trying to see what we can do better. We're trying to improve," he said.

Buttgieg often cites the fact that he tore down a thousand dilapidated and unoccupied properties in the city. And yet, those thousand lots now lie vacant. "Many would say that's not rejuvenation yet," Achkar said.

The city's transformation "can't be boiled down to a campaign slogan," he added.

Beyond concerns about Buttigieg's local success, one of the central questions surrounding Buttigieg's run is the degree to which South Bend actually represents Indiana, the Midwest, and the country as a whole. Would a candidate like Buttigieg succeed in attracting Rust Belt voters?

When it come to the city's voting patterns, Achkar said, "South Bend is not reflective of Indiana at all." While Hillary Clinton garnered only 47 percent of the vote in broader St. Joseph County, defeating Trump by only 200 votes, South Bend proper has consistently elected Democratic mayors and city councils.

When it comes to voting, South Bend is representative of many metropolitan areas in the country: a Democratic urban pocket surrounded by rural populations that vote Republican. Due to its strong manufacturing past, South Bend has always had a base of voters who are part of unions, most of whom have historically voted Democrat. The presence of higher education institutions like Notre Dame contributes to a more Democrat-leaning population, as does the city's ethnic diversity.

Because Buttigieg hails from a blue island within an increasingly red state, his appeal in his own region may be fairly limited. As an openly gay candidate who frequently speaks about issues like climate change and gun violence, Buttigieg may find it challenging to attract support from Midwestern blue-collar voters.

IN 2016, Buttigieg organized a campaign event in South Bend for Hillary Clinton. "You could just tell the enthusiasm wasn't there," he told *The Washington Post* in January 2019, explaining how the establishment candidate lost because the stakes seemed too low. What the party needs now, he said, is "a bigger scope of ambition for people."

"Change is something we need to face with clear eyes. It's scary, but it's also exciting," he told the *Post*.

Lyandres said she was always drawn to Buttigieg's energy and drive. "A few years ago, I was having a conversation with a few of my friends. And I said, 'He's going to run for president.'"

As Buttigieg prepares for the national stage, Luecke is still thinking about South Bend's future. Whether Buttigieg wins or loses his run for president, he will not be seeking another term in South Bend. As Buttgieg faces a future beyond town lines, Luecke wonders what's ahead at home: "Now," he said,"we're looking at who will be the next mayor."



BAKING MY WAY HOME











Inside Fair Haven's Mi Lupita Bakery

BY **OSCAR LOPEZ AGUIRRE**

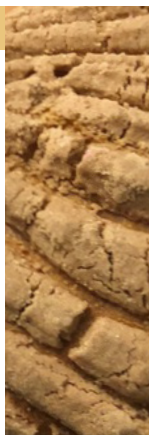


PHOTOS BY **OSCAR LOPEZ AGUIRRE**

IF YOU WANT TO BE Mexican-American, all you need to do is like Selena and *conchas*. That's it. Some of you might be halfway there. Liking (or pretending to like) the former is easy—type her name on YouTube, click the first video, and say, "UGH! I LOVE SELENA!" as if you had seen her performance at the Astrodome, one month before her death in 1995 and three years before your birth. Do this in front of your friends, and half of your "Mexican Card" materializes in your back pocket. Liking the latter is a little harder (even though everyone falls in love at first bite)—you have to get up, sit in a car or a train or a wagon and head to your local (or not so local) Mexican bakery. Hope to God that the small shell-shaped pastry—*la concha*—sits in a stainless steel tray. If you happen to find it, break this bread with your friends, and no one can deny your Mexicanness.

However, your Mexican Card has an expiration date. I know mine is about to run out when conversations with my mom are littered with too many "ummm's" as I search for words in Spanish, or when previously mild foods have a surprising kick, or when I write in English even though I know the words *ni le llegan a los tobillos* ("don't even reach the ankles of") the Spanish ones. Although Selena, and therefore half of the card, can be conjured in a single click, finding the key to the other half, the *concha* half, tends to be trickier. Finding this iconic Mexican sweet bread in the States is difficult, especially in the very white, non-Mexican-bakery-having city of New Haven, Connecticut.

La Casa, Yale's Latino Cultural Center, does its best to be a home away from home, with its sponsored dinners and Spanglish-speaking staff. But it doesn't completely relieve my homesickness. Once, walking into La Casa's kitchen, I spotted an unmistakable brown bag. The splotches of oil seeping through the paper immediately told me that the *concha*—the manna of Mexico, the elusive requirement for connecting to home—was inside. I asked my friends Sandra and Fernando where they had found it, and they handed me a plastic business card: Mi Lupita Bakery in Fair Haven, the predominately Latin-American side of the city. The next day, I boarded a bus bound for the *panadería*, located at 269 Grand Avenue, in an attempt to renew the other half of my Mexican Card.



THE SMALL BAKERY is squeezed between a Mexican *tienda de antojitos* ("cravings shop") and POPS Grocery Store, which sells winning lottery tickets (its window brags, "WE SOLD A $5000 WINNER"). Stickers of *La Virgen de Guadalupe* and another Catholic saint deck the bakery's windows. Typically, in Mexican Catholic imagery, chubby angels hold up the saints, but these windows are different. Below the saints, where angels should be, stand mountains of bread.

When I visited for the first time, it struck me that the bread sold here isn't just any bread. It's holy.

My American ears preemptively expected a bell or an electronic *ding-dong*. Instead, laughs and conversations—people saying hello, trading words of admiration, *compadre* and *comadre*, all in Spanish—greeted me as I approached the front counter. It didn't sound like a bakery. It sounded like a home.

Under a single naked light bulb, two humble stacks of bread flanked the room—brown savory breads to my left, colorful sweet breads to my right. I peered around the corner and saw several women sitting



The *concha* is the Pumpkin Spice Latte of Mexican-American youth.

around a metal table. One of them acknowledged me and mimed that I should grab a tray and tongs. I reached into the stack of bread to my right and picked out a couple of *conchas*.

A woman came to the counter and rang me up. I handed over a few wrinkled dollars and settled into a chair tucked in the store's corner. As I ate my bread in seclusion, my entire Mexican Card in hand, I still had the desire to break this invisible boundary, from "*A sus ordenes*" to "*Hola, Óscar*," from customer to friend, from friend to family—at least a second cousin.



BEFORE EUROPEAN COLONIZERS crossed the Atlantic, Mesoamerica had a staple crop. From the tops of the Andes Mountains to the sagging valley of central Mexico, maize defined the Mesoamerican palate. The closest thing to a baked good was the *tortilla*, a flattened circle of maize dough heated on a clay griddle.

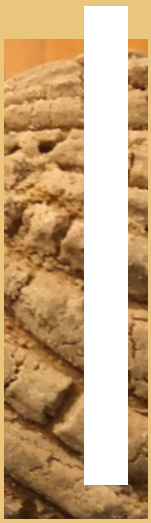
European colonizers brought things with them that Native Mexicans never wanted: a language that was too lisped for Mexicans' tastes, a few fleets' worth of blankets seasoned with *just* enough smallpox, and a new staple crop that these sick, lisping people called *trigo*: wheat.

Only after the fall of Tenochtitlán and the Aztec Empire did wheat become a viable crop. Juan Garrido, a free African conquistador, brought wheat from the Old World. After Garrido helped Hernán Cortés topple the Aztec Empire, he couldn't find a job in the colony, so he crafted one of his own: he began to plant wheat on a small farm and inadvertently introduced bread-baking to Mexico.









The first Mexican bakeries were open-air markets in plazas outside major buildings like government offices and churches. Native women tucked pieces of bread into wooden baskets and sold their merchandise to passers-by. One of the most notable early *panaderías* was Mexico City's *Plaza Mayor*, which became the biggest site of bread sales in the entire country. Women aimed to sell every slice and chunk by the time the church bells rang, when they had to stop selling, cut their losses, and join the crowd inside.

By the 16th century, Mexico had adopted and redefined bread-baking. Mexican bakers began adding indigenous ingredients—like vanilla, sugar cane, corn flour, and cacao—to European bread recipes, creating *pan dulce*. These sweet pastries came in all shapes, textures, and tastes: from the crispy sugar-glazed cookie called *la oreja* ("the ear") to the cinnamon-infused dinner roll topped with two crisscrossing braids of bread and sesame seeds called *el pan de muerto* ("the bread for the dead").

Of all these pastries, the shell-shaped *concha* became the symbol of a new wave of Mexican-Americanness. Today, *conchas* appear all over websites that have anything at all to do with Mexican-American millennials; designers have turned the bread into earrings and pil-

lows and stickers for fake nails. The *concha* is the Pumpkin Spice Latte of Mexican-American youth.

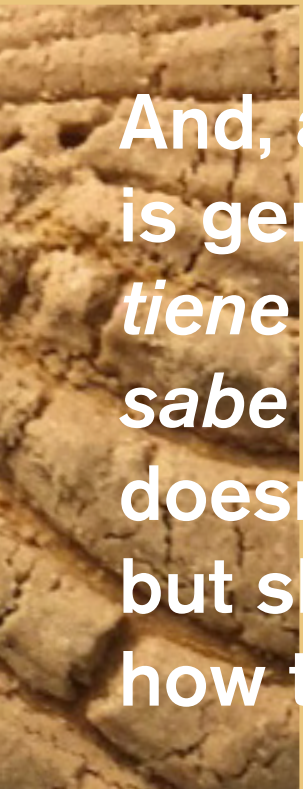
THE WOMAN IN CHARGE of this modern-day *Plaza Mayor* is Yolanda Guzmán. She is short and stout and has the arms of someone who knows how to cook. Her hair is thick but not particularly curly. Fly-away hairs shoot out from the constraints of her bun. She has round, deep brown eyes with eyelashes coated in what looks like a permanent layer of mascara. Her skin is bronze, and I immediately guess that she is from southern Mexico, near the Yucatán Peninsula. She wears a checkered purple *mandil*—a rectangular piece of cloth with front pockets that serves as an apron. This is the symbol of Mexican motherhood, Mexican domesticity, and Mexicans not having enough time to tie unnecessary knots.

Yolanda gestured for me to join her in the back, where the kitchen was functioning at full force. Flour coated the surface of a wobbly metallic table dotted with tiny mounds of dough. Yolanda's son was busy cutting the freshly-mixed dough into portions. He dressed in athleisure—an Adidas tracksuit and a T-shirt. He concentrated on cutting the dough and measured it on an old metallic scale.

In the left-hand corner of the kitchen, next to the old blacktop stove, Yolanda's sister, Beatriz, wrapped tamales. Steam from a pot of *sopa de fideo* curled over the stovetop; the smells of tomato paste and yeast did battle in the air. Although I felt comfortable seated in the back, I soon had to dance around the kitchen as people shuffled in and out, and I became more of nuisance than a guest. The hum of the refrigerator took over the kitchen, as determined work silenced all talk. I saw what I had long hoped to see: the making of *la concha*.

Yolanda took a piece of dough from her son and slapped the lump onto the table. Cupping her hands, she spun the dough in a circle until it flattened. Then she passed the dough to her brother Adolfo, who laid it on wax paper on a steel tray and brushed it with liquid butter. By the time I turned back to watch Yolanda, she had already finished shaping eight of the dough patties that would form the bases of the *conchas*.

She now held a *tortillera*—a heavy iron contraption that looked like a waffle maker from antiquity. Lifting the lever, she laid a tiny lump of brown, sugary dough on the machine. She clamped the mouth shut and forced the lever down until the dough mound became a thin pancake, which would become the sweet top of the *concha*. Adolfo took it and laid it on one of the *concha* bases on the tray. He then cut three curved lines into the *concha*'s surface, did this for each *concha*, and passed the tray to his brother, Alberto, who stood by the oven. Alberto stacked tray upon tray in the oven until it was full.



And, above all, she is generous: *"No tiene mucho pero sabe dar."* She doesn't have much, but she knows how to give.

I WAS INVITED to bake bread on Halloween night. In the kitchen, Yolanda, Beatriz, Adolfo, Adolfo's wife, and Adolfo's three young children were discussing trick-or-treating plans. The eldest of Adolfo's children (six years old) was dressed as Iron Man, the middle child (three) as a ladybug, and the smallest (two) as a lion. The kids grabbed a bucket of candy and headed to the front of the shop to share with other children. I wandered deeper into the back, grabbed a black apron, and washed my hands at the sink.

Yolanda stood poised in front of the metal table, her dough ready for me. Unfortunately, no matter how close we get, she'll never give me her recipe. She explained the one task I was to complete: shaping blobs of dough into smooth balls.

To demonstrate, she grabbed a piece and smacked it against the metal table with a thump, sending up a cloud of flour. She cupped her hands and spun the dough on the table. Within ten seconds, the lump had become a small neat sphere ready for the oven.

On my first try, I struggled. The dough felt foreign in my inexperienced hands, more like Moon Sand, moving slow as goop. When I cupped my hands like Yolanda and moved them in a circle, the table wobbled, as if threatening to collapse. Eventually, the

dough began to take form, sticking to itself.

I repeated the process over and over. The dough smelled a bit unpleasant—like a damp newspaper, not like the sweet *concha* from my childhood. It got hotter the more I spun it. After a few seconds, I could no longer feel the difference between the dough and my palms. But the most surprising thing was that no matter what I did with the dough, it stuck together. Whether I flattened it with my fist, pressing down with my entire body weight, or stretched it as wide as my wingspan, the dough would always find a way to fall back into itself.

FAMILY IS STICKY like dough. Yolanda's family hails from Tlaxcala, Mexico, a state that sits just outside the country's capital. In Tlaxcala, people tend to be shorter and browner and look more like the people who inhabited the country before the Europeans came. As a child, Yolanda loved traveling with her family to sell bread all over the country, in cities like Mexico City, Puebla, and Guanajuato. Bread meant mobility, both spatial and economic.

Now, Yolanda presides over her own bakery as matriarch, the head of a business with a long tradition, surrounded by her siblings and her only son. It occurred to me that though her family has changed, at its core, it will always be the same: no matter how it looks, whether tragedy tries to flatten it or whether distance tries to stretch it, it will always tend toward itself—it will always stick. And as Yolanda kneads her dough in her small bakery in Connecticut, her family in Mexico kneads its own.

Yolanda left to go trick-or-treating with the kids. I sat in a foldable chair behind the metal table where I had rolled the balls of dough. Beatriz, Yolanda's sister, began stacking the layers of a *tres leches* cake, squirting condensed milk into the spongy bread from a bottle. I had tried to get to know Yolanda better by asking questions, but she tended to glaze over everything with a layer of sweetness—everything was *bien* or *bueno* or *sí*.

Beatriz didn't glaze things over as much. She asked about my family: my sisters, my parents, whether or not they were hardworking or smart, and whether or not I liked them. She followed the tangent with, "Sorry if I'm asking too many questions." I said it was fine. I knew I was about to return the favor.

Beatriz told me many things about her sister: Yolanda is hardworking and caring and humble. She is more like her mother than her father. And, above all, she is generous: "*No tiene mucho pero sabe dar*." She doesn't have much, but she knows how to give.

I had experienced this first-hand. Yolanda would never let me leave without a free bag of fresh bread. She always offered me *sopa de fideo* and tamales despite my repetitive *Ya comí*'s ("I already ate"). I soon learned to visit on an empty stomach.

I asked whether or not they planned to make an altar for *Día de los Muertos*. She said, "*Sí y no*." They wouldn't make a huge traditional altar, adorned with pictures of their deceased loved ones. They would simply leave a piece of bread and a cup of water. "*Para un alma que no tenga donde ir*." For a soul that has no where else to go.

AS I LEFT THE BAKERY on Halloween night, I peered at the pastry trays and didn't see any *conchas*. Beatriz said they had sold out. On the street, I couldn't shake the smell of yeast and flour. I had found a home not in the *concha* nor in the bakery—maybe not even in Yolanda's family—but in the baking of the bread. Identity, I thought to myself then, cannot be encapsulated and consumed. It has to be made.

There is a Mexican saying that all Mexican people have cacti on their foreheads. It's not as painful as it sounds: it just means that Mexicans can recognize each other. The people who dreamed that up probably never baked a piece of bread in their lives. I'd like to think that all Mexicans have the smell of a *panadería* stuck in their nostrils, the smell of flour and yeast clinging to their nose hairs. When you least expect it, the smell returns and lingers like a ghost and urges you to look for your home.



Not free, not fair, not credible

Did Britain Back a Zimbabwean Autocrat's Re-election?

BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

WHEN ZIMBABWEAN SOLDIERS shot civilians during riots against alleged election-rigging on August 1, 2018, many Zimbabweans were horrified—but they weren't surprised.

The previous November, the dictator Robert Mugabe, whose 37-year rule was marked by brutality, rigged votes, and economic collapse, had been overthrown in a military coup. With the coup leaders' support, the ruling Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF) quickly announced that Mugabe's right-hand man and former Vice President Emmerson Mnangagwa—always ambitious, occasionally insubordinate, and widely loathed as the regime's ruthless enforcer—would assume the presidency he had long coveted.

Mnangagwa was Zimbabwe's spy chief during Gukurahundi, a series of mid-1980s massacres that targeted the Ndebele minority and killed an estimated 20,000 people. Two decades later, in 2008, Mnangagwa coordinated a campaign of terror conducted by the army and pro-government militias. The violence won Mugabe's re-election—but only after more than 180 people, mostly supporters of the main opposition Movement for Democratic Change (M.D.C.) party, were murdered.

In November 2017, thousands celebrated Mugabe's ouster in the same streets of Zimbabwe's capital, Harare, where Mnangagwa's army would spill blood less than nine months later.

Early in his presidency, Mnangagwa promised reforms. In January 2018, he traveled to Switzerland and assured the World Economic Forum that Zimbabwe was "open for business." He also promised "free, fair, credible elections, free of violence" within months.

Britain, Zimbabwe's former colonial power, welcomed Mnangagwa's commitment to change. And as Mnangagwa pledged, Zimbabwe held an election on July 30, 2018.

Mnangagwa officially won a second term as president, defeating M.D.C. leader Nelson Chamisa. But election observation missions backed by the U.K., U.S., and European Union (E.U.) concluded that the vote was not free or fair.

The post-election violence killed six, and the months prior to the election saw intimidation, state-media bias, and abuse of government resources—all in favor of Mnangagwa and his party, ZANU-PF.

But to many Zimbabweans, then-British Ambassador to Zimbabwe Catriona Laing seemed at best unconcerned by these warning signs. Some in the M.D.C. and Zimbabwe's independent media and civil society thought Laing, and possibly the British government, wanted the authoritarian Mnangagwa to win the election.

New President, Old Zimbabwe

DESPITE MNANGAGWA'S worrisome history, foreign governments, including Britain's, had reason to believe he could be an improvement over Robert Mugabe—mostly because that was a low bar to clear.

Mugabe assumed power when Zimbabwe gained its independence in 1980. For 20 years after that, despite his proclaimed Marxist and African nationalist leanings, he maintained positive relations with Britain and other Western countries.

But by the late 1990s, Mugabe turned against the West. Starting in 2000, he encouraged his supporters to seize Zimbabwe's commercial farms—a legacy of colonial rule—from their predominantly white owners, at times with violence.

Simultaneously, Mugabe's government violently repressed the newly formed M.D.C. opposition, civil-society groups, and independent newspapers. The regime also misused state funds, scared off investors, and tried to fix these problems by printing more money,

leading to the world's worst hyperinflation.

Zimbabwe's drop in economic prosperity under Mugabe was dramatic. Per capita GDP was lower in 2011 than in 1981, according to World Bank data, and a 2014 government survey found that only 5.5 percent of workers had formal jobs.

Mugabe blamed Western countries—which imposed sanctions on ruling party heavyweights, including Mugabe and the future president Mnangagwa—for Zimbabwe's ills. This strategy extended beyond economic woes: In 2008, Mugabe's then-information minister, Sikhanyiso Ndlovu, attributed a cholera outbreak to British biological warfare.

It was unsurprising, then, that the U.K. was glad to see Mugabe go. "We were hopeful, I think, that if Mnangagwa was serious about being different, this was an opportunity to reset," said Conor Burns, a British member of Parliament (M.P.), in an interview with *The Politic*.

Fifteen months later, however, that opportunity has all but disappeared. Under Mnangagwa, Zimbabwe's economy has continued to falter, and the country now faces a severe cash shortage. In mid-January 2019, mass protests against fuel-price increases were met with a merciless crackdown by security forces: the Zimbabwe Human Rights NGO Forum recorded 16 deaths, 26 abductions, and 81 gunshot injuries over three weeks.

Soldiers raped women and broke the legs of opposition activists. The government ordered two internet shutdowns and detained more than 900 people, justifying arrests mostly by alleging violence or looting during the protests.

Addressing the U.K. parliament at the end of January, British Minister of State for Africa Harriet Baldwin strongly condemned the crackdown as "all too reminiscent of the darkest days of the Mugabe regime."

On February 5, Baldwin said Britain "would not be able" to support

"We were hopeful, I think, that if Mnangagwa was serious about being different, this was an opportunity to reset."

Zimbabwe's application for readmission to the Commonwealth of Nations, an association of 53 countries that are mostly former British colonies. (Mugabe had unceremoniously withdrawn Zimbabwe from the Commonwealth in 2003, and Mnangagwa had been eager to rejoin.)

At least until the election, however, Mnangagwa seemed to have the support of one key British diplomat: the ambassador to Zimbabwe, Laing, whose term in Harare lasted four years and ended in September 2018. Laing did not respond to requests for comment sent to the British high commission in Nigeria, where she is currently posted.

The Ambassador and the Scarf

SOME POLITICIANS IN BOTH the U.K. and Zimbabwe suspected that Laing sided with Mnangagwa in last year's election. Burns and fellow British M.P. Kate Hoey visited Zimbabwe in May and June to observe election preparations, and Burns said the visit program, organized in part by the British embassy in Harare, "definitely had a very strong pro-ZANU-PF, pro-Mnangagwa slant."

Before one dinner, Laing was "openly ridiculing" M.D.C. leader Chamisa, according to a report the M.P.s released later. (Laing denied this allegation in a tweet.)

Burns said, "There is no question in my mind at all that...our British ambassador in Harare at the time was very biased towards President Mnangagwa." Burns noted that when Laing traveled to London in March 2018, she was photographed wearing the same scarf, patterned in the colors of Zimbabwe's flag, that Mnangagwa had worn at the World Economic Forum in January.

ZANU-PF adopted the scarf as campaign regalia, and according to Hoey and Burns' report, Laing's decision to wear the scarf in London caused "huge offence" among Zimbabweans the M.P.s met.

But Celia Rukato, who designed the scarf, told *The Politic* it was originally meant as a symbol of national pride and not partisan preference. Rukato said of Laing, "When she wore it, I took it as trying to say, 'Zimbabwe's got a bright future.'"

For Laing's critics, the scarf photo was only one instance of her alleged bias. "That was the physical manifestation," human rights lawyer and former M.D.C. Senator David Coltart told *The Politic*.

When Zimbabwean Foreign Minister S.B. Moyo visited the U.K. in April 2018 to tout his government's narrative of a post-Mugabe "new dispensation," Laing accompanied him.

"I found [that] extraordinary,"



Campaign posters for Zimbabwean President Emmerson Mnangagwa and his party, ZANU-PF, are seen from a Harare street.
PHOTO BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

Coltart said. "I've never seen any other ambassador of any country in Zimbabwe, certainly, in the last 30 years do that."

Xavier Zavare, who serves as the secretary for administration of ZANU-PF's diaspora branch in the U.K., dismissed the opposition's complaints as "funny, weird, misinformed, ignorant allegations."

Zavare said the M.D.C. mistook Laing's "noble way of engaging" with the ZANU-PF government for bias.

"The opposition in Zimbabwe, they feel they've got an entitlement to being supported by foreign ambassadors, especially from Western countries," Zavare told *The Politic*.

Coltart acknowledged that in public statements, Laing was "very diplomatic, she couched her language very carefully. She was always at pains to say Britain did not have any favorites."

But he continued, "It became clear through private meetings, one-on-one conversations, that certainly the approach of the ambassador was to favor Mnangagwa."

"A Blind Eye"

WHY MIGHT LAING have wanted Mnangagwa to win re-election, as some allege?

Eddie Cross, a former M.D.C. M.P. who has informally advised Mnangagwa's government, told *The Politic* that Laing was concerned about stability and considered Mnangagwa the "only credible center of power" in Zimbabwe after the coup.

"She didn't hold Nelson [Chamisa] in high regard at all," Cross added.

It is unclear how much Laing's alleged personal preference might have affected British policy. "I can find little evidence that she softened the stance of the British government," said Cross.

Even so, Burns said that "elements of the [U.K.] Foreign Office, unquestionably led by the ambassador... were turning a blind eye when it was becoming blindingly obvious that all was not well with those elections."

According to the London-based publication *Africa Confidential*, Laing and her husband Clive Bates held a pre-election meeting in July with Zimbabwean civil-society groups receiving British funding. The NGOs alleged that they were "encouraged to focus less on the risk that ZANU-PF would use the state and the military to rig

"Almost anyone you spoke to in the opposition camp told you as a matter of course that the British were well-disposed towards Mnangagwa. It was a sort of conventional wisdom."

the election and more on the risk that the opposition would 'spoil' the election to protest electoral irregularities."

In the end, it was the government, not the opposition, that sent troops to shoot civilians on August 1. Soldiers then harassed and beat M.D.C. supporters for days afterward, and later in August, Baldwin said the U.K. was "gravely concerned by the violence and human rights violations."

For Ben Freeth, a white farmer tortured by pro-ZANU-PF militias during the land seizures, Britain's realization that Mnangagwa's government could be as brutal as Mugabe's should have come much earlier.

"We've got exactly the same monster still in power," Freeth told *The Politic*. "Nothing has changed."

Before the Coup

KHOLWANI NYATHI, EDITOR of Zimbabwe's *The Standard* newspaper, believes Laing was partial to Mnangagwa even before he was president.

Speaking with *The Politic*, Nyathi recalled a meeting with Laing a few months before the November 2017 coup. At the time, a fierce battle to succeed Mugabe was dividing ZANU-PF.

Mnangagwa was vice president, and Mugabe's wife Grace, the country's first lady, was Mnangagwa's most powerful enemy. Although she never said it, Grace Mugabe was widely believed to hold her own presidential aspirations.

Nyathi said that in the meeting, Laing "sounded to be really forcing a line that Mnangagwa is the person to work with, and she wanted our opinions around that."

ZANU-PF's opponents have alleged a years-long close relationship between Laing and Mnangagwa. "When he was vice president, Catriona Laing had already started working *for* Mnangagwa, if not working with him," said Jealousy Mawarire, currently a spokesperson for the opposition National Patriotic Front party, in an interview with *The Politic*.

Mawarire said Laing requested to meet him in October 2016, when he was working for a different opposition party, Zimbabwe People First.

"She purported to want to understand how the Zimbabwe People First was faring as a political party," Mawarire remembered. "But to my surprise, when she came, all the questions, everything that she wanted to know was whether Mnangagwa had chances of succeeding Mugabe."

Guided by Laing, the British were "arguing that Zimbabwe needs a strongman," said Tendai Biti, a senior opposition figure, when speaking with South Africa's *Daily Maverick* newspaper in 2016. "By that they mean a man called Emmerson Mnangagwa, who suddenly is a reformer."

British journalist Martin Fletcher reported from Zimbabwe in 2016. "Almost anyone you spoke to in the opposition camp told you as a matter of course that the British were well-disposed towards Mnangagwa. It was a sort of conventional wisdom," he told *The Politic*.

Britain Changes Course

AFTER THE M.D.C. was founded in 1999, Mugabe accused Western countries, and especially Britain, of backing the opposition party as part of a regime-change plot.

In 2004, when then-British Prime Minister Tony Blair told the U.K. parliament, "We work closely with the M.D.C. on the measures that we should take in respect of Zimbabwe," Mugabe's allies seized on the slip to attack the M.D.C. as a "British puppet."

But the M.D.C., then led by Morgan Tsvangirai, failed to unseat Mugabe in three consecutive unfair elections.

"It became clear that ZANU-PF was so entrenched that they would probably not give up power," said Alex Magaisa, a former advisor to Tsvangirai, in an interview with *The Politic*. "And I think that in about 2013 or 2014 or thereabouts, or maybe earlier, [Britain] decided to change course and decided to work with a faction of ZANU-PF which they thought would be progressive or pragmatic."

Catriona Laing arrived in Harare in 2014. "I don't think that any ambassador works in a vacuum," former M.D.C. Senator Coltart said, explaining that he thought Laing received "broad instructions" from London on how to approach Zimbabwe's political scene.

According to Stephen Chan, a professor of world politics at SOAS University of London who told *The Politic* he maintained "good relations" with Laing, the rivalry in ZANU-PF between Mnangagwa and Grace Mugabe was a crucial factor in the ambassador's thinking.

According to Chan, Laing believed "a very great deal more pragmatism was likely to come out of Mnangagwa's camp than out of Grace Mugabe's camp."

But the coup would have taken place regardless of Laing's opinion, and in Chan's view, once Mnangagwa was president, the Foreign Office simply sought to work constructively with him as a national leader.

M.D.C. supporters accusing Laing of helping Mnangagwa win re-election were "just searching for things that don't really exist," Chan said.

Open for Business

BLESSING-MILES TENDI, a professor of African politics at the University of Oxford, believes that preferring Mnangagwa over Grace Mugabe—as most foreign diplomats in Zimbabwe did—was not logical.

"You want to think in terms of lesser evils," Tendi told *The Politic*. And for Tendi, the lesser evil was Grace Mugabe.

Tendi pointed to Mnangagwa's role in Gukurahundi, in the 2008 election violence, and in the Democratic Republic of the Congo's civil war at the turn of the century. The Zimbabwean military intervened in the war and worked with ZANU-PF-linked businessmen to illegally mine and sell Congolese diamonds. A 2002 United Nations report identified Mnangagwa as a key figure in the Zimbabwean "elite network" responsible for the plunder.

"[In] the darkest episodes in Zimbabwe's history, Emmerson Mnangagwa's name is central," Tendi said. "Not Grace."

But Mnangagwa was perceived, both domestically and internationally, as a pro-business pragmatist potentially capable of reviving the economy that Mugabe had run into the ground.

Magaisa, the advisor to Tsvangirai, found it plausible that the U.K. was eyeing business opportunities in mineral-rich Zimbabwe. (Magaisa did not have a "firm opinion" as to whether Britain favored Mnangagwa in the 2018 election.)

In March 2018, Mnangagwa's government relaxed a Mugabe-era law that limited foreign ownership in multiple sectors. "Investment opportunities in Gold, platinum, coal, chrome, nickel, copper, lithium, tin, tantalinte [*sic*], iron ore, coal bed methane, natural gas, and more," advertises the website of the Zimbabwe Mining Investment Conference 2019, scheduled for August, where Mnangagwa will be the guest of honor.

"Britain is also facing its own crisis with Brexit, and if they leave the E.U., they're going to have to chart their own course," Magaisa said. "And I think that Zimbabwe and other countries around the world will become more and more important in terms of business."

But Cross and Tendi reasoned that for the U.K., any benefits of post-Brexit trade with Zimbabwe would be negligible. Though vast, Zimbabwe's mineral reserves are largely undeveloped, and the current cash crisis makes the country an especially risky bet for foreign firms.

"You can get this stuff anywhere else for less hassle," Tendi said of Zimbabwe's natural resources.

If not economic benefits, Britain may have sought influence in its former colony—but with Mugabe reviled across the British political spectrum, improved relations with Zimbabwe were off the table until Mugabe was out of office.

Julia Gallagher, a professor of African politics at SOAS University of London, explained the British government's logic: "If we get anyone other than Mugabe, we can then begin to explain how we're justified in re-engaging."

Tendi added that, in his view, Brexit *did* encourage Britain to embrace Mnangagwa after the 2017 coup, just not in the most obvious way.

"It's not so much about trade, markets, or anything like that," Tendi said. "If you bring Zimbabwe in out of the cold, and Britain is seen as facilitating that...the symbolism that Britain still has a role outside the E.U. has significance."

But Britain has been accused of

supporting Mnangagwa's ambitions once before: in 2002, long before Zimbabwe's coup, and when Brexit was still a fringe idea.

A British-backed Succession Plan?

IN 2002, ZIMBABWE faced inflation and impending famine, and M.D.C. leader Morgan Tsvangirai lost his first unfair election to Mugabe, although the opposition did not recognize the result, and Western countries condemned the election as severely flawed.

Retired Zimbabwean army Colonel Lionel Dyck and then-commander of the Zimbabwean military General Vitalis Zvinavashe drew up a plan under which Mugabe could cede power—to Mnangagwa.

In December 2002, Dyck approached Tsvangirai and Geoffrey Nyarota, the then-editor of the independent *Daily News*, which was strongly critical of ZANU-PF. Tsvangirai and Nyarota received different stories about the succession plan from Dyck, but both involved Britain.

According to Tsvangirai's version of events, published in a February 2003 article by South African journalist Allister Sparks, Dyck wanted to discuss Mugabe's potential retirement, and he also told Tsvangirai that an officer of the British intelligence service, MI6, had asked Dyck to make his initial approach to Zvinavashe, before the plan to put Mnangagwa in charge had been laid out.

Dyck, who now lives in South Africa, declined to be interviewed for this story. But Tendi, who said he has known Dyck for seven or eight years, believes Dyck was not acting on behalf of British intelligence.

"He detests everything British," Tendi said, explaining that working for MI6 would involve too much politics for a professional soldier like Dyck. "He doesn't like dealing with the Brits at all."

In Tendi's view, Dyck, motivated in part by his business interests—at the time, he ran a landmine-clearing company called MineTech—approached Zvinavashe with hopes of finding a peaceful solution to Zimbabwe's crisis.

"I was not planning to kill Mugabe," Dyck explained in a 2012 interview with Tendi. "I wanted to arrange a safe retirement plan for him and stop the country's economic decline."

Also in December 2002, South African M.P. Patrick Moseke, claiming to negotiate on Mnangagwa's behalf, requested to meet with David Coltart of the M.D.C. in Johannesburg. There, Moseke proposed to Coltart that the M.D.C. could get token representation in a unity government led by Mnangagwa.

The opposition refused to play along. "The feeling within the M.D.C. was that the approaches were designed to co-opt the M.D.C. as a minority player in a process to sanitise the ZANU-PF regime and leave it in power," Coltart later wrote in his autobiography, *The Struggle Continues*. On December 18, 2002, Tsvangirai released a statement condemning "this dirty plan...endorsed by ZANU-PF, the British, and the South Africans."

In 2008, Nyarota wrote that Dyck told him of talks with Tsvangirai's rivals in the M.D.C., Welshman Ncube and Paul Themba Nyathi, about a plan that would "sideline both Mugabe and Tsvangirai."

Dyck wanted the *Daily News* to support the plan, but an unimpressed Nyarota exposed it in the paper instead, with a hint of a British connection.

"It is understood Dyke [*sic*] has also established contacts with...politicians in London in a bid to canvass support for a new ZANU-PF-military driven political agenda," the *Daily News* reported on December 19, 2002.

In his interview with Tendi, Dyck said that he had sought support for the succession plan—it remains unclear which version—from both the U.K. Foreign Office and the U.S. State Department. "It was interesting, talking to the Brits and Americans, that they were quite happy for ZANU-PF to continue in power as long as Mugabe was not there," Dyck recalled.

Dyck "didn't say that there was anything close to universal support for Mnangagwa" in the Foreign Office, Tendi noted.

Convenient Allegiances

BUT IBBO MANDAZA, who was the editor and publisher of Harare's *Sunday Mirror* newspaper when it reported the succession plan story in January 2003, is convinced of a link between suggestions of British backing for Mnangagwa in 2002 and the allegations that dogged Catriona Laing last year.

In a 2014 editorial in the *Zimbabwe Independent*, Mandaza argued that Mnangagwa's rise in ZANU-PF was a victory for Zimbabwe's "securocratic state"—the country's military elite. "Our army was trained by the British," Mandaza told *The Politic*.

British advisors trained the Zimbabwean army between 1980 and 2001. In 2017, Hazel Cameron, a lecturer in international relations at the University of St. Andrews in Scotland, conducted an analysis of Foreign Office cables from the period of the worst Gukurahundi massacres, in early 1983. She concluded that both British diplomats and military advisors were well aware of the Zimbabwean army's atrocities yet chose to downplay them, believing Mugabe's government was an important strategic partner for the U.K.

Coltart, who defended dissidents during Gukurahundi as a human rights lawyer, does not think Britain's current policy toward Zimbabwe is motivated by cold political calculus.

While acknowledging Britain's economic interests, Coltart took care to note the historical, artistic, and sporting ties between his country and the U.K.

"It's a multifaceted relationship between Britain and Zimbabwe," Coltart said, "and I think both sides would like to restore that relationship."

But for some in Zimbabwe's opposition, civil society, and independent media, trust in the U.K. is already gone. An editorial comment published on February 7, 2019 in the independent daily *NewsDay*—no friend of Mnangagwa—denounced the British government's "self-serving" condemnation of the January crackdown.

When Zimbabweans wanted a free and fair election, *NewsDay*'s editors reminded readers: "[T]he British told anybody who cared to listen that Mnangagwa was the man of the moment and required international support."

The editorial called for dialogue in Zimbabwe and, from Mnangagwa, reform. "To the British, please leave us alone," it concluded. "[Y]ou have already failed us when we needed you most."

Protesters Unite Against Philippine President Duterte, in Photos

BY **SAMMY WESTFALL**

ON JULY 23, 2018, thousands of Filipinos wiped sweat from their foreheads in Metro Manila's scorching heat as they marched down a highway in opposition to Philippine President Rodrigo Duterte's tyrannical policies. Two kilometers away, clad in the traditional *barong* shirt of the Philippines, Duterte was making his third annual State of the Nation Address (SONA) from the air-conditioned House of Representatives chamber. As Duterte boasted about his accomplishments, the 8,000 protesters outside—who called themselves the United People's SONA—lambasted him for his dictatorship, extrajudicial killings, and attacks on freedom of the press.

Each year, SONA, infamous for its ostentatiousness, brings together nearly 3,000 Philippine politicians, Cabinet members, and Supreme Court justices, who walk down a red carpet flanked by photographers before they enter the House of Representative Session Hall. In 2013, the late Senator Miriam Defensor Santiago blasted SONA's frivolity, stating, "The SONA event should be a serious time for the Congress to pick up policy directions indicated by the president. It should not be treated as Oscar night in Hollywood, with a red carpet, where peacocks spread their tails and turn around and around, as coached by media in a feeding frenzy."

1.



PHOTOS BY **SAMMY WESTFALL**

UPON HIS ELECTION IN 2016, Duterte launched a national drug war, abiding by his campaign promise to stamp out drugs from the country. Since then, the Philippines has seen thousands of drug-related extrajudicial killings, mostly by police officers in the dead of night. The Philippine National Police reported 4,500 killings in two years, though this number is contested; Human Rights Watch put the number at 12,000 in 14 months.

At SONA 2018, Duterte reiterated his commitment to the drug war: "The war against illegal drugs is far from over. The illegal drugs will not be sidelined, instead [the war against them] will be as relentless and chilling…as on the day it began."

"WE ARE JOINING this United People's SONA primarily because of the intentional distortion and attacks [on] human rights concepts and principles. [The distortion] is confusing the people into accepting the repression that has been going on," Rose Trajano, secretary-general of the Philippine Alliance for Human Rights Advocates, told me at the protest.

"[Duterte] is a charismatic leader…we cannot deny that," Trajano explained. "The people only…take actions when [an issue] really affects them. The war on drugs doesn't affect everyone—only the very poor people."

Trajano continued, "We are very saddened because of the culture of violence—it is with us now. The culture of impunity, the culture of disrespect to human rights—that is the most difficult challenge we will have after Duterte."

2.





3.

DONNA MIRANDA of the National Federation of Peasant Women, or AMIHAN, traced the bodies of demonstrators with white paint, in memory of the 142 farmers who had been killed under Duterte's regime. Most of these farmers were peasant leaders who fought local governments for their right to land, food, and justice, she told me.









WHEN I ASKED TEDDY LOPEZ, a protester with the opposition coalition Tindig Pilipinas, what he hoped to hear in the 2018 SONA, he replied quickly: "Nothing. I hope for nothing." Lopez explained, "I wish [Duterte] wouldn't deliver it anymore because it's useless. It's just going to be a litany of lies. So *yun*, what's there to hope for in this SONA? Nothing."

4.







5.

A ROW OF YOUNG CHILDREN lined the sidewalk of the highway, hoping to join the march and yelling "Boo-terte! Boo-terte!" They pushed each other, waved at passing protesters, and made paper planes out of leaflets that activists were handing out. A mother fanned herself as she watched the children from a plastic chair set outside her house. She was watching the protest, too.

PROTESTERS KEPT UP with Duterte's 48-minute SONA through livestreams and televisions set up on the side of the highway. Duterte's voice was difficult to hear over the the perpetual stream of drum beats and voices denouncing his human rights violations.

"Your concern is human rights, mine is human lives," Duterte announced from his podium. The audience in the Session Hall applauded politely. I stopped by the side of the highway to watch Duterte speak.

6.





7.

DUERTE ANNOUNCED HIS INFRASTRUCTURE PROGRAM, "Build, Build, Build," in 2016. Costing 180 billion dollars, the 75 high-impact flagship projects would spark economic growth and include nine major railways, six airports, and many new roads and bridges. In 2018, construction had begun on only seven projects.

LUI JAY, 18, WHOSE FAMILY owns a corner mechanic store, said that he appreciates Duterte and all that he's done. He told me in Tagalog that last year, this area—Commonwealth Avenue—was more *magulo* (chaotic). "*Walang hubad, walang tambay,*" Lui Jay said—there were no longer any "*hubad*" (shirtless people) loitering around his stall.

In 2018, Duterte directed the police to arrest *tambays* (loiterers)—including minors—and put them in custody to "protect" them from drugs. In less than two months, thousands were brought to police stations for "anti-*tambay*" charges.

Former Human Rights Watch Deputy Asian Director Phelim Kine wrote in a statement that "the [police are] conducting a 'crime prevention' campaign that essentially jails low-income Filipinos for being in public."

Lui Jay told me that Duterte had made the country more "disciplined." When I asked him if he had felt any fear under the new president, Lui Jay said that he was afraid of being accused of drug use. Fearful of being arrested, he said that he often stays inside. Still, he remains an ardent Duterte supporter.

8.



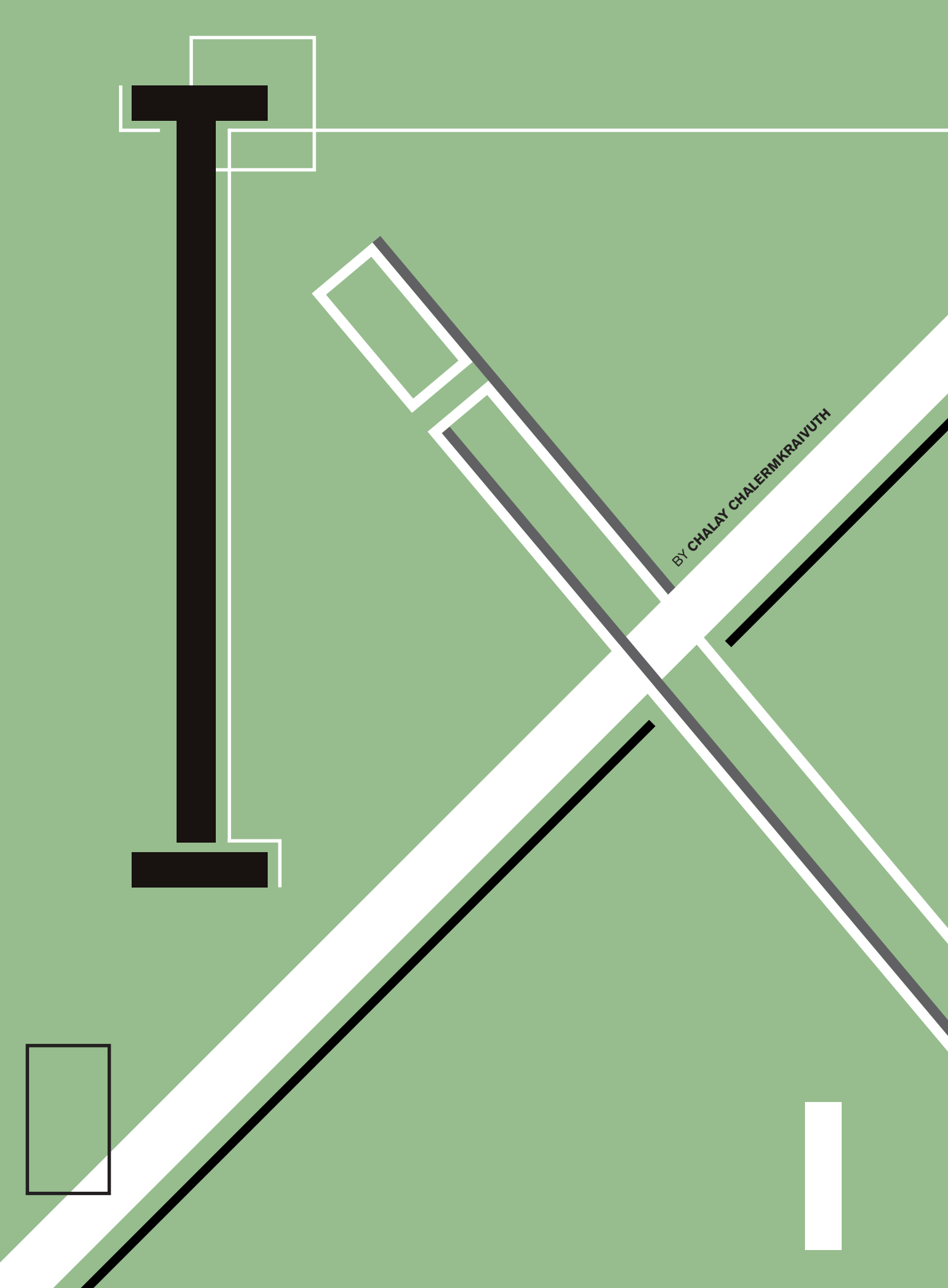




9.

"IF YOU THINK THAT I can be dissuaded from continuing this fight because of [your] demonstrations, your protests—which I find, by the way, misdirected—then you got it all wrong," Duterte said in his address.

To end the protest, demonstrators burned a giant effigy of the president, which depicted his face on a train. The "DuterTRAIN" sculpture, created by activist art group UGATIahi, evoked TRAIN, Duterte's new tax policy, which raised excise taxes on fuel and levies on sweetened beverages. Singing voices and drum beats resounded as the activist art piece was lit on fire. The crowd grew larger and the air turned hotter until the entire sculpture of Duterte had burned to the ground.


BY CHALAY CHALERMKRAIVUTH

A LENGTHENING SILENCE

What an Unusual Title IX Case Reveals About Power in Academia

A QUEER, FEMALE PROFESSOR of German and comparative literature at New York University (NYU) is found guilty of sexually harassing a gay, male former graduate student and advisee. Has there ever been a story as easily weaponized in the service of reactionary agendas as Avital Ronell's?

The story first surfaced in May 2018, when philosopher and legal scholar Brian Leiter leaked a letter on his blog, *Leiter Reports*. The letter, which had been circulated widely among left-leaning scholars, was a defense of Ronell, whom NYU's Title IX office had investigated for sexual harassment. NYU was then in the process of determining her sanction. Fifty-one academics had signed their names in support of Ronnell.

The letter's language was lightly, politely threatening. It charged the complainant—Nimrod Reitman—with "malicious intent" and made pointed note of Ronell's "international standing and reputation." Signatories included a host of more-or-less-leftist luminaries like Columbia University's Gayatri Spivak and renegade philosopher Slavoj Žižek. The letter writers' identities are unknown—perhaps because the circulation of details prior to sanction is a violation of Title IX confidentiality rules—but feminist theorist Judith Butler later became the letter's unofficial spokesperson and apologist: she was its first signatory, not to mention one of the most prominent scholars alive.

Writing to the editor of *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, Butler explained the letter's diction and her own position: "Our aim was not to defend her actions—we did not have the case in hand—but to oppose the termination of her employment as a punishment. Such a punishment seemed unfair given the findings as we understood them," she said. She added, "The letter was written in haste. … We all make errors in life and in work."

Leiter's blog post disturbed the surface of the small pond of academia. Numerous professors claimed that the letter they agreed to sign was not the letter that Leiter leaked. Some said they had been told that Title IX had cleared Ronell of all charges (in fact she'd been found guilty of sexual harassment) and that NYU was nonetheless moving to unjustly fire her within three days (Ronell was eventually suspended, without pay, for a year). One email had stated that a lack of response would constitute consent to sign.

In other words, bad faith was rife. Edward Sullivan, an art history professor at NYU, told *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, "The author was totally unauthorized to add my name to the letter. I have brought it to her attention. I know nothing further about this affair." Other professors have not been so firm in retracting their support. Spivak told *BLARB*, the blog of the *Los Angeles Review of Books*, "I'd rather not comment … Loyalty gets in the way of the law."

The story dipped back into obscurity until August, when *The New*

York Times published Reitman's account of Ronell's sexual harassment, in a story titled, "What Happens to #MeToo When a Feminist is the Accused?" The article detailed physical and virtual harassment, excerpting emails where Ronell called Reitman her "cock-er spaniel" and demanded that his language be more sexual and amorous. Two further articles—one written by a graduate student in the Comparative Literature department and published in *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, the other written by the German department's former dean and published in *Salon*—portrayed Ronell as a narcissist and tyrant for whom sexual harassment was only one of multiple means of abuse and control.

FOR A WHILE, I DIDN'T think to look at the letter. But when eventually I did, my breath stuck in my throat. It hadn't occurred to me that I might know anyone on the list personally, as I do Paul North, professor of German at Yale. He'd been my favorite professor in the spring of 2018, when he co-taught a course on critical theory in Latin America. Another Yale professor of German, Rudiger Campe, was also among the signatories.

To this day, North, Campe, and the German department have not issued public statements on the subject of the letter, although, according to graduate students, they have offered private explanations—claiming that the letter they signed was not the letter Leiter leaked—in department meetings.

These explanations may have sufficed for the students and faculty members I did not speak to. But for the graduate students I did communicate with, the lengthening silence has evidenced a failure far more unsettling than the misinformed offering of a name to a cause: the failure to take seriously the precarity of graduate students and to take stock of power in academia.

It is somewhat misleading that the Ronell case was framed as a quirky variation on the theme of #MeToo, when the inequality that it manifested arose not from the patriarchy, but from the hierarchical structure of academia. According to a report by the American Association of University Professors, 73 percent of all faculty positions in 2016 were off the tenure-track, which largely translates to minimal job security, low pay, and no benefits. The casualization of academic labor and the resultant hyper-competitiveness of the job market render graduate students particularly reliant on anything that might secure their futures. The Ronell case is a disturbing illustration of the extent to which graduate students' livelihoods hinge upon their advisors' goodwill.

"There are no jobs," said one German graduate student at Yale, who wished to remain anonymous. "We are structurally dependent on good letters of recommendation from big-name advisors. If no one writes you that stellar recommendation letter, and if that person doesn't have a big name in the field, you're less likely to get one of the scarce jobs that are available. Ultimately one has to ask oneself, why did Nimrod Reitman feel compelled to go along in that situation and to tolerate that abuse of power on the part of Avital Ronell? Probably because he was extremely anxious about his job prospects. And that goes beyond just pure sexual harassment. That speaks to a basic imbalance of power."

Graduate students occupy an uncertain position whose lack of formalization leaves them largely powerless. Despite their status as university employees, they have no contracts and no unions and are therefore largely unable to advocate for themselves in their departments or to the administration. Despite their status as students, their mentoring from professors can be patchy: no formal structure outlines how much mentoring professors owe each student.

It is particularly ironic that one popular defense of Ronell has ostensibly sought to protect the sanctity of mentorship in academia, even as mentoring relationships are rarely deeply personal, erotically-charged exchanges of ideas. Most often, they are hands-off. If anything they are a little *too* hands-off.

"I find that I have been mostly left on my own, and most of the time I like that," said Sophie Duvernoy, a third-year student in Yale's German department. "But when things get hard,

> But universities like Yale not only fail to establish structures that prevent abuse, rather than address it after the fact; they also still actively look to hire "stars."

I sometimes wish someone would check in on me, and usually the burden is on me." As it stands, there are no provisions against either over- or under-involvement.

Meanwhile, professors are, uncomfortably, senior colleagues, advocates, and mentors, all at once. According to the graduate students I spoke to, if anything taints the mentoring relationship, it is not Title IX, and it would not be unionization; it is the fact that professors—rather than a third party, or graduate students themselves—are currently responsible for advocating for graduate students to the Yale administration on matters of funding and wage inequity. Graduate students in language departments, for instance, teach classes independently, five days a week, and receive the same stipend as students who, in their capacities as teaching fellows, assist one or two professor-led classes and lead one section a week.

"Institutional change that affects our lives is currently dependent on the goodwill of our department and its ability to press against the administration to give them certain things, and that depends on their energy levels and their ability to stretch themselves thinner for a fight that's not their own," said Duvernoy.

Another student, who preferred to remain anonymous, said, "I'd just prefer to have a regular intellectual conversation; I don't want to ask anyone, 'Can you please advocate on my behalf?'"

IN THE PUBLIC SPHERE, factions battled for control of the narrative following the *New York Times* article. Obfuscating discourse ensued:

"Ronell and her cronies...undermine foundations of reason and virtue," polemicized Gilbert T. Sewall for *The American Conservative*. "They punish deviations from their theoretical confections with sadistic delight."

Right-wing commentators, adding Ronell to the list of women accused of sexual misconduct, gleefully portended the self-destruction of #MeToo. *The New York Times* did its part to discredit feminism by calling Ronell a feminist scholar, though she is in fact a Germanist and deconstructionist, more at home with Derrida than with de Beauvoir.

Meanwhile, academics waged smaller skirmishes. Brian Leiter denounced "theory," seeking to discredit not only all the leftist luminaries who had signed the letter but also their work, dismissing swathes of scholarship on everything from literary theory to marginalized communities. Ronell's defenders denounced the death, at the hands of Title IX, of the kind of idiosyncratic charisma and life-changing mentorship that Ronell supposedly gave out in spades: "I'm depressed that this seems like the end of any but all but [*sic*] the most technocratic pedagogy," wrote Chris Kraus, theorist and novelist. (It did not seem to register that "idiosyncratic charisma" and "life-changing mentorship," often synonyms for unchecked power and free zones for abuse, were themselves part of the problem.)

Other signatories looked to exempt Ronell on the grounds of her gender and her queerness, suggesting that it was for these aspects of her identity, rather than for her wrongdoings, that she was being condemned: "This is misogyny of the variety pervasive on the internet. Misogyny is rife even among the queers and feminists posting personal attacks—they do not do this to similarly accused male faculty," claimed queer theorist Lisa Duggan, Ronell's colleague at NYU.

All of these readings of the events proved wrong, either mostly or entirely. The death of #MeToo did not pan out. The death of "theory," to the extent that it is happening, owes itself mostly to a lack of humanities funding. As for the deaths of academic stars, academic freedom, academic "integrity": professors found guilty of sexual harassment or assault tend to retain their jobs, regardless of gender. Ronell's suspension is a far cry from the revocation of tenure that professors who signed the letter were told was imminent. People are still reading Judith Butler. In this sense, the fallout, though sensational, has been uneventful, like a meteor that doesn't strike the earth. In the meantime, the true lesson of the Ronell case—that graduate students are vulnerable and that professors, including those who study power, wield power over them—has, in institutions of higher education, remained unlearned.

Why was Title IX Nimrod Reitman's sole means of recourse? Why, in other words, did it take a case of sexual harassment for Ronell to be held accountable, in however limited a fashion, for what appears to have been serial abuse that was only occasionally sexual in nature? Title IX, previously used to redress sexual harassment as a form of sexual discrimination, now redresses sexual harassment that gives rise to inequality of educational opportunity more broadly. This includes harassment that gives rise to "an intimidating, hostile, or offensive working environment." However, the fact that Reitman resorted to a means of dealing with case-by-case issues of sex, rather than structural issues in academia, speaks to a paucity of other, more powerful, more pertinent means of redress. It also speaks to the way that problems are typically handled: by isolating them, by narrowing culpability to individual actors, by making them private and small. Ronell's punishment, though necessary, doesn't alone solve the problem.

In spite of Title IX's limitations—or perhaps because of its tendency to individualize problems—it has aroused some fear amongst faculty. In 2016, the American Association of University Professors published a report warning against the possible infringements of Title IX on academic freedom of speech. The report condemns "[t]he failure [of Title IX offices] ... to distinguish between 'hostile-environment' sexual harassment and sexual assault" and "[t]he use of overly broad definitions of hostile environment to take punitive employment measures against faculty members."

Eerily, one of the report's six authors, Joan W. Scott, signed the letter in

Ronell's defense and then stood firmly by her decision to do so: "This is an example of a kind of misuse or abuse of Title IX," she told *The Chronicle*. This paranoia loses sight of the fact that few professors have lost their jobs as a result of Title IX investigations, and that graduate students have few other methods of recourse, especially if professors aren't listening. At worst the report looks to justify faculty exceptionalism, ignores academic hierarchies, and raises the specter of faculty precarity over the reality of graduate student precarity.

Of course, most professors are not Avital Ronell. But universities like Yale not only fail to establish structures that prevent abuse, rather than address it after the fact; they also still actively look to hire "stars": professors who combine excellence in their fields with charisma that may, in Dean of Humanities Division Amy Hungerford's words, "invite boundary-crossing, adulation, discipleship."

Hungerford described the manner in which such stars, left unchecked, may warp the fabric of their scholarly communities. "The qualities that make for a charismatic teacher-scholar can sometimes be the very qualities that lead to the sort of boundary-crossing and power dynamics that we see in the Ronell case. A charismatic person makes others want to connect to them, and their authority comes from the desire of others for that connection. This connection is felt to be seductive or transformative in some way for the less powerful person, for the disciple. Basking in the attention of a charismatic leader is a powerful experience, and losing that attention, or feeling the disappointment of such a leader, can be felt as devastating," she wrote to me in an email. "In situations where hierarchy and authority are not highly formalized, or where these are complexly structured (academia fits this bill) charismatic authority is particularly potent and compelling to others, and has genuine effects on the careers of those surrounding the charismatic figure."

In a later email, she added, "I would say that many people contemplating these figures at other places have a healthy perspective on whether outsized charisma is what one needs in a particular department or field at a particular time. Truly charismatic figures are rare and complicated. Sometimes we want them to live among us; sometimes we want to be inspired by them, and then go home to an orderly house."

Of course, charisma should not endanger students. Neither is it always what students need or want. Mentorship is not a trade-off between teachers who are uncharismatic and unabusive, and teachers who are charismatic and potentially abusive.

There is a different path for professorship, one that does not privilege any single aspect—writing, or research, or solipsistic intellectual output—over the others that equally constitute the work of academia: pedagogy, mentorship, the even-handed administration of a department. In the words of Max Chaoulideer, a fifth-year German Studies student at Yale: "The practice of academia and the theory of academia should not be distinct."

THIS JUNE, STUDENTS AT Island Avenue Elementary School in Madison, Connecticut, will leave for summer vacation, but they will not return in the fall. The school no longer has enough students to fill its classrooms.

The school's closure, which has been planned for years, is scheduled to take place this summer. The children enrolled in Island Avenue will be transferred to one of the district's two other elementary schools.

"Since 2010, we've had a decline [in] enrollment," Madison Superintendent Thomas Scarice explained. In a span of ten years, the number of students in Madison has decreased by nearly 1,000. "We made a commitment that once it got to [the middle and high school] level, we would look to contract from six schools to five."



CONSOLIDATE CONNECTICUT?

The Debate Over School Regionalization

BY **MOLLY SHAPIRO**



Island Avenue is not the only school struggling with a shrinking student population. Districts across Connecticut are seeing fewer students enroll every year, pressuring lawmakers in Hartford to find a solution. One popular proposal is regionalization—also known as consolidation—where multiple schools merge into one, or districts share administrative functions such as janitorial services and IT departments.

"People are concerned about [the] declining population because you want your towns to prosper and to grow. We're concerned," Natalia Smirnova, a Salisbury Board of Education member, said.

She blames Salisbury's shrinking school population on high property taxes. "Our town is prominent because it has a lot of second homes of New Yorkers, so the property tax is high, which precludes young families who want to move into the district," she added.

But Scarice suspects the widespread declining enrollment also has something to do with birth rates. "Birth rates are definitely down nationwide," he said, "especially in Connecticut."

In 2016, the Center for Disease Control's National Center for Health Statistics released data showing Connecticut has one of

the lowest fertility rates in the nation, with only 53.4 births per 1,000 women—significantly lower than the national average of 62 per 1,000 women.

"It's tough. Small towns become attached to their small neighborhood schools," Scarice said.

TWO CONNECTICUT BILLS have made school regionalization the subject of recent controversy.

Senate Bill 454, introduced by Senate President Pro Tempore Martin Looney this legislative session, would force school districts in towns with fewer than 40,000 residents to consolidate with a nearby district. In an interview with *The Connecticut Mirror*, Senator Looney stated that his proposal aims to improve "educational efficiency."

The other proposal, Senate Bill 457, introduced by Senate Majority Leader Bob Duff (D-25) and Senator Cathy Osten (D-19), would require school districts with fewer than 2,000 students to join with a nearby regional school district. Duff identified school regionalization as "a way in which we can save the state precious resources and also work to increase student outcomes."

Duff believes that by consolidating administrations, school regionalization would eliminate resources spent on overhead costs. Cutting costs is particularly important in Connecticut, which will face a 1.5-billion dollar budget deficit in fiscal year 2020.

But Duff stressed that his proposal is not radical: "Nobody is saying that schools have to close," he said. "You would just have fewer administrators because the money that the state sends goes into administration rather than the classroom."

State Representative Susan Johnson (D-49) echoed Duff's concerns about the state's education funding. She said suburban schools are losing students, despite receiving the same funding as more populous areas. "We need to make sure that we're not building more schools in areas where we're losing population," she explained.



"ANY TIME YOU LEAD decision-making of public school children with a financial goal in mind, you could warp what you're trying to do: educate kids optimally," Scarice said.

Few dispute that the budget is at the center of these proposals. But lawmakers and school officials question whether regionalization is the best solution for the state's financial challenges.

Because so much education funding comes from local sources, the state may not actually save much money by implementing mandatory regionalization.

"In a district like Madison—an affluent suburban community—our state funding is fairly minimal," Scarice said. He explained that most funding for schools comes from local property tax dollars and estimated that only three to five percent of schools' budgets comes from the state.

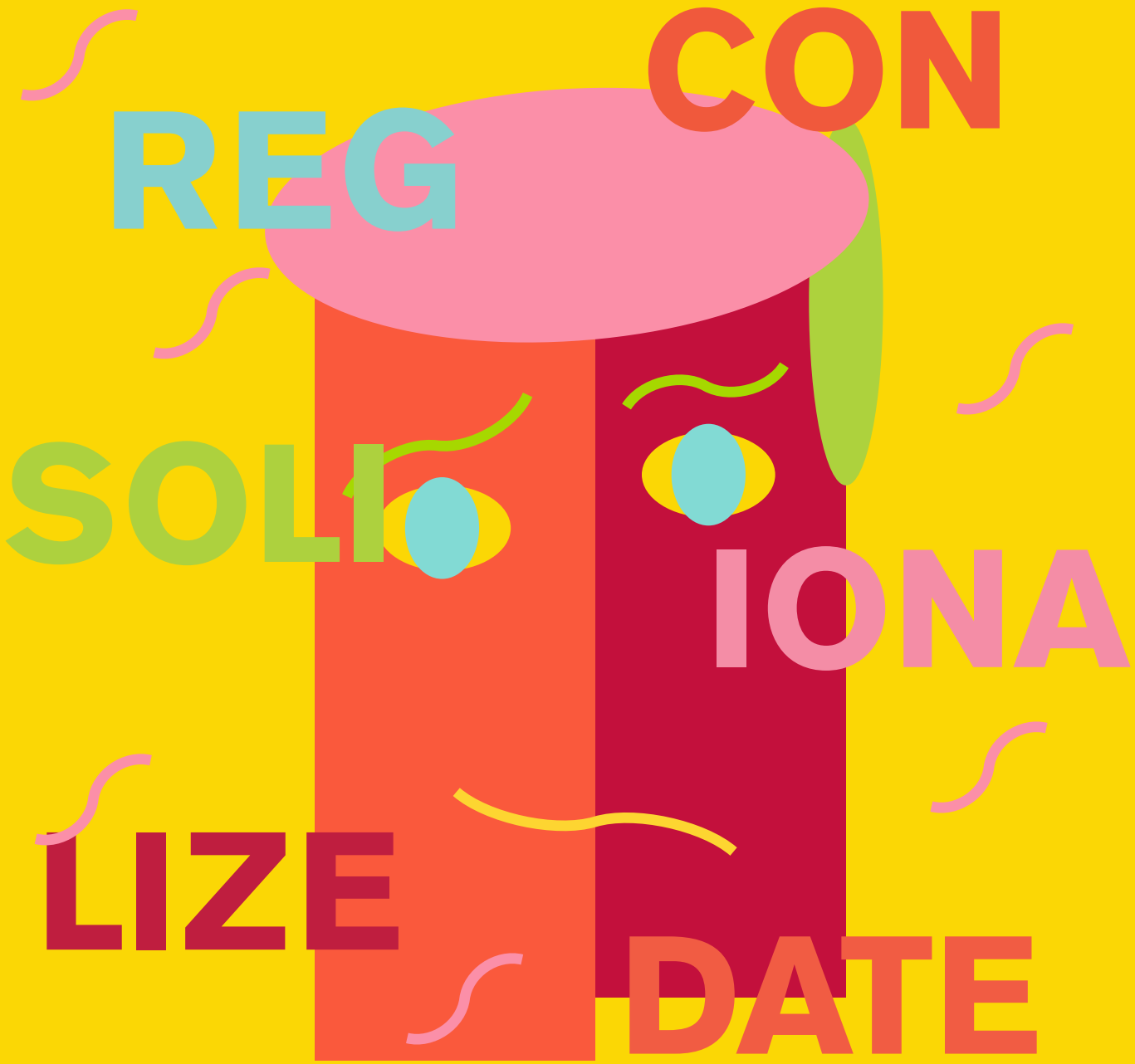
Substantial local funding means that local taxpayers have a "big stake" in education funding because so much of the money is theirs, Betsy Gara, the executive director of the Connecticut Council of Small Towns, explained.

Gara, along with many lawmakers, worries that regionalization proposals would result in a loss of local control. Inevitably, locals will have less of a say in their school system as it expands to encompass more towns, each with their own set of interests.

For similar reasons, Kevin Smith, superintendent of Wilton, Connecticut, called mandated regionalization "repugnant."

"The problem that I have is the assumption that regionalization automatically confers efficiency," he said. "Ultimately, what I see is a loss of local control. So if a smaller town like Wilton was forced to regionalize with a larger town, then I'd have questions about... the governance structure there."

Smith questioned what would happen in the case of a referendum on funding in a regional school district. Would Wilton be beholden to the will of voters in the larger town?



Representative Vincent Candelora (R-86) also raised concerns about what the bills would mean for local budgetary control. "When we had our education funding cut by Governor Malloy mid-year, districts that were regionalized had no way of dealing with that," he said.

While the local elected officials of North Branford, a town that has not regionalized its schools, were able to approach the Board of Education about balancing their budget, regionalized districts were unable to do so, Candelora explained. "Towns had no way to make up for those cuts," he said.

SALISBURY, WHICH HAS ALREADY implemented school regionalization, is facing the consequences of this policy change. Salisbury is part of Region One, which consists of eight towns that all send students to one regional high school. The towns give money to the region proportionate to the number

of their students who attend the school.

The problem, Smirnova explained, is that anytime there are programmatic changes (the hiring of a new administrator, for example), her town must pay more money to the region. "Our board got really upset because we don't have anything to do with who they're hiring there, but we are spending more and more money because we're supposed to support the programmatic changes they're doing," she said.

Smirnova also cited governance challenges created by regionalization: "The superintendent cannot govern well because she has to have the approval of eight boards. She spends all her time going to boards and presenting."

In addition to a loss of local control, Smirnova explained that her district saw a loss of jobs. Although teachers can typically transfer to work at the consolidated school, nurses, custodians, and principals—who have positions that are harder to come by—do not have that luxury. "There were five principals, now there is one," Smirnova said.

"THEY'RE GOING TO GET a lot of grassroots resistance," Candelora said of the two bills.

Though it is likely that the bills will not pass in their current form, lawmakers see opportunities for compromise. Many critics of mandatory regionalization would still support letting districts voluntarily adopt regionalization, as towns such as Salisbury have done.

"We certainly support efforts to promote voluntary approaches to regionalization," Gara said. "The issue we have with the bill is that it's a top-down, forced consolidation approach without regard for what the impact will be on municipal costs. We're very concerned about any effort to force consolidation in a way that is a one size fits all approach."

Senator Duff, however, is skeptical that voluntary regionalization is a viable solution. "The voluntary approach doesn't seem to be working so well," he said. "It hasn't happened."

Because the proposals are still in their early stages, ample time remains for rethinking and revising. Regardless of the fate of his bill, however, Duff is certain that change is coming.

"The need is great and this should have happened a long time ago," he said. "I'll look at it optimistically and say that this is the beginning of a conversation, and one way or the other this is going to happen, whether it's through legislation or other means in the state of Connecticut."

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China's Rebellious Daughter

On Losing a Language

BY **ALLISON CHEN**

THE FOOD WAS DELICIOUS.

Two large round tables filled the white-marbled room. Pretty, twenty-something-year-old waitresses carted steaming, expensive plates of food, light pooling from the glass chandelier above. Relatives I barely knew smiled at me, asking me questions about life in America. As the clink of wooden chopsticks against porcelain bowls grew quieter, my voice—my deliberate Mandarin—carried on about school in America, the coveted freedoms of an American high school senior, the friends I already sorely missed only two weeks after graduation.

They smiled encouragingly before me, the extended family I had not seen for six years due to increasingly busy summers. After all, this was the first time I had visited China since sixth grade, the one summer with no obligations. A great desire to recount everything from those missing six years, crucial adolescent years that contained all of middle school and high school, spurred my excited storytelling, before I paused for a breath.

"Ting ting."

It is Great-uncle's voice that interrupts the pause, my name spoken quietly, slowly—as if it were an afterthought.

All heads swivel toward him, the chopsticks halting for the first time—except for his.

Great-uncle continues easily, plucking food languidly from the center dishes, picking at the small grains of rice in his bowl. He gazes curiously at me, as if I had done something to surprise him.

His eyes flick to my mother, and he smiles in a dry, wistful way.

"*Keoi m sik gong baak waa*?"

She cannot speak Cantonese?

He is the only one to have noticed—or the only one with courage to say it.

In the entire 30 minutes leading up to his question, I had responded to every relative not in those same rough, familiar consonants of Cantonese, but in starched, clipped Mandarin. I knew, then, that he had been waiting—waiting for me to prove myself, to prove that, yes, I still had the Cantonese within me, that I had not completely forgotten the mother tongue—no, I don't mean China's official language; I mean the real language of these streets.

Great-aunt waves her frail hand in the air, as if physically brushing away the pause like an annoying gnat, and laughs. "Why would an American girl need to know the dialect?"

The entire table chimes in agreeing chuckles, and the conversation moves on, mothers scooping more food into their children's bowls, the men bending to light each other's cigarettes as they do at every meal.

Yet I catch Great-uncle's tightened lips and brief slump of shoulders.

The twinge in my throat is not an-

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ger or annoyance, but shame.

It is the strangest experience—the ability to understand a language but not speak it. Over the years, my grandparents, who now live with us in the Arizonan desert, and I have unknowingly adopted a system: they speak in Cantonese and I reply in Mandarin, both using languages the other can comprehend but not use.

But once, I could.

I have seen camcorder videos of four-year-old me, climbing over desks and drawers, shouting in energetic, raucous, lovely Cantonese—every word spoken as if it were my native tongue.

That girl is foreign to me.

Sitting with the white napkin folded primly in my lap, eyes trained on my oily plate, I quietly remember my parents suddenly forbidding me from speaking the dialect out of fear that it would accent my Mandarin. My mother once explained that I couldn't possibly have become perfectly fluent in all three languages at such a young age, and that there was only room for Mandarin and English. She told me that these are the useful languages. These are the important ones. And plus, when would I ever use Cantonese in my adult life?

However, it is not just me that my parents' generation chastises, but many other young children.

In mainland China, kindergarten teachers punish children for speaking their local dialects instead of Mandarin. According to the Pew Research Center, by 2020, about a third of Hispanics will speak only English at home because Hispanic Americans are becoming less and less likely to pass Spanish down to the next generation. A boy in Catalonia will forget the local tongue of Catalan because of the pressure on schools to teach in the national Castilian Spanish instead, due to fears of children being shortchanged in Spanish. Over and over again, we are so willing to discard the old—to let the next generation forget the past.

Strangely enough, there always seems to be a contradictory hope that the child somehow still preserves that ignored language and culture. That even with all forces pointing toward more standardization, more modernization, the younger generation will somehow, in some way, retain the culture that was covertly pushed away.

Whenever I conversed with Grandmother as we played with multicolored pieces of Chinese checkers



in the Arizona heat, I found myself, again and again, wanting to slip into her language, to show her that I can know and understand her words exactly—not just an internally translated version of them. I constantly yearned to reclaim those forgotten intonations, even as I delighted in learning economics jargon in Spanish and listened to political broadcasts in Mandarin. Like the aftermath of those Chinese *kongque* dance performances where I must eventually shed my traditional costume for the quintessentially American cutoff shorts and tank top, perhaps this is yet another experience I can never be fully a part of, where I will, again, be an other, a foreign individual.

Throughout that dinner, I attempt to push aside those residues of shame, to brush away and dismiss Great-uncle's comment like they all had, to continue making merry conversation in my polished, trained Mandarin.

Yet even as we stroll outside, moving from the glossy room to the cluttered streets of Zhaoqing, my mother's hometown, the strains of the dialect burst like cannons through the air. The outdoor market haggling between middle-aged women, the harmonies of Cantonese folk songs that the old street musician sang nightly over strums of his *erhu*, even the vulgar joke I caught between two boys in their elementary school uniforms—these sounds touch me like a forgotten tune.

A language is more than its modern "usefulness." It is place, history, emotion, and collective consciousness.

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I have lost melodies of the only permitted port of 19th-century Chinese international trade, a portal to the poppy flower that ruined a nation, and the blazing fires of the temporary Chinese capital during the Chinese Civil War.

In those summer nights I spent in China, I stood on a concrete bridge that rose over the bustling small-city traffic. The sweet, musky Zhaoqing air of summer clung to my mosquito-bitten skin. Like a lover, the breeze left traces of itself all over my body—the pungent cigarette smoke of the potbellied clerk who greeted us every night, the sweet toxic haze of all that vehicle exhaust, the steam of meaty pork dumplings from the boisterous vendor downstairs. I smell it in my skin, my hair, on the nights I lie in the netted mattress. It is not China, but her rebellious daughter that teases me like that once-was lover. She taunts me, revealing what I once knew and what I may never know.

"A Connection Among All of Us"

An Interview with Cristina Jiménez Moreta, Co-founder of United We Dream

BY **ERIC WALLACH**

CRISTINA JIMÉNEZ MORETA is the co-founder and executive director of United We Dream, the largest immigrant youth-led network in the country, comprising over 400,000 members, five statewide branches, and over 100 local groups across 28 states. After the failure of the DREAM Act, Jiménez Moreta was instrumental in United We Dream's successful push for President Obama to sign Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) into law. For her work as a social justice organizer, Jiménez Moreta received a 2017 MacArthur Fellowship, the Four Freedoms Award, and a spot on the 2018 *TIME* 100 list.

***The Politic*: European and Asian immigrants make up 20 percent of the undocumented population, yet very few people suspect them of "illegality." What does that mean to you?**

Jiménez Moreta: The central trend here—to address a narrative and a framework of "illegality"—is race and racism. What we see underneath the efforts to label all immigrants as less than human and to criminalize them is a way to then justify any action by the government, whether that is family separation, kids in cages, the kidnapping of children, deportation, or the denial of access to due process. Through the immigration system's laws and different institutions in American society, immigrants—particularly immigrants of color—must experience systematic racism and oppression every day.

We are seeing these stories all across the country. United We Dream has a deportation hotline and an app called Notifica, where we support community members around interactions that they have with ICE. We just had a father, Jorge Sarango, who was detained in New York but then transported to a jail in Alabama, very far away from his family, where he experienced mistreatment in the jail facility where he was held. It was community organizing that was able to get him released. But now he is dealing with a lot of the trauma, and we are still fighting his deportation. He has kids that are less than eight

years old, who have now also been traumatized by this entire experience. We are seeing entire families being mistreated in the name of living in this country "illegally," every single day, as evidenced by Jorge's story.

How do we humanize undocumented immigrants and get to know their perspective without demanding too much of them? What does United We Dream do in that respect?

I grew up undocumented, feeling really afraid of sharing that I was undocumented to anyone. When I got to share my story with some fellow undocumented young people, I felt such a huge relief and also a sense that I was not alone anymore and that I had a community around me. But sharing with the broader community outside of United We Dream spaces and sharing the diversity of experiences of immigrants from different continents, immigrants that have faced different journeys to get here—whether that is coming with a visa or going through the river and/or multiple borders to get here—is also critical to our work. All of those are stories that lift up both the struggles and the conditions that lead many of our community members to come to this country, but also their dreams and their aspirations and how they relate to many of the stories of other people. They create a connection among all of us, and I think that has really helped us also humanize the conversation around immigration, rather than pedaling a really manufactured debate, a narrative, that has aimed to take away our humanity and criminalize families and people like my own parents.

As an undocumented immigrant, you won the MacArthur Fellowship. In many ways, you are that person who creates a collective feeling of pride and excitement for undocumented immigrants. Is it exhilarating? Is it tiring? Is it both?

For me, the recognition around awards and/or fellowships like the MacArthur

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Fellowship is significant because they recognize the sacrifice of my own family, my own parents, coming here and leaving it all—risking so much to ensure that, unlike my father who grew up homeless in Ecuador, I could have a better life. Recognitions like this are also a recognition of immigrant families across the country just like us. If we can bring some hope, some inspiration, and some motivation to our community, that brings me a lot of joy. It sends a message to our community that they are seen and that they are valued, because everything else is telling them they are not valued, that they are not worth it, that they are not wanted—that instead, this government and this society want to get rid of them.

And with that joy, it also brings greater responsibility. I would not say that it gets tiring; for me, it is always more of a question of how I am using my voice, my platform, and my visibility to bring more people along from my community, whether that is opening up opportunities, showing that our community is visible in places where we are not visible, or expanding the conversation to recognize an immigrant community that is diverse. Our community does not only have the business owners, the entrepreneurs, the academics, or the scientists. We have them, but we also have working-class families and people who are struggling in a very difficult economy and a society that has been designed, unfortunately, to limit opportunity for communities of color.

Part of the responsibility of my platform is to expand the conversation beyond the "good" and the "bad" immigrant, or the "excellent" immigrant, to not perpetuate the same oppressive and dehumanizing narratives that have been created to target our communities, to rather humanize the conversation and challenge the discourse to ensure more and more that we are getting closer to a day in this country where people of color and immigrants will be able to live without fear. I know that is a dream that I share with millions of people in this country. I just see my story, what I can do through my platform, and the different places or conversations that I am part of as a contribution to those efforts to one day get to that vision.

Read more of this interview on thepolitic.org.

on-line pre-view

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